Chris batted with incredible power and simplicity, standing tall at the crease and typically bludgeoning the ball in the 'V' between mid-off and mid-on. For him, the bat was a club. For Virat, the bat was a surgeon's knife, and he so often proved himself uniquely skilled at placing the ball in the gaps.

For me, it was a privilege to spend so much time with two of the finest batsmen ever to play the game, training with them, partying with them and getting to know them as friends. There has never been any kind of rivalry between us because we have grown to understand and respect each other.

'Come on, you little biscuit.'

'OK, let's play, you little beauty.'

Virat and I share a liking for nicknames, and we have become very tight over all these years. He is an incredibly generous person, generous with his advice, generous with his time and generous with his support. He's also a ferocious competitor and, many times, he has driven the team, and me in particular, to new heights.

There have been some fantastic occasions when everything clicked and we seemed almost unbeatable but, to be honest, our performances as a team have been generally disappointing. Some have suggested the balance of the RCB squad has never been quite right, with the depth of our bowling rarely matching the depth of our batting but, whatever the reason, we have too often performed below our potential.

In 2012, we won eight of 16 group matches. Chris Gayle averaged over 60 in 14 innings, and I picked up three Man of the Match awards, but we finished in fifth place and narrowly missed out on the knockout stages with a marginally inferior net run rate to CSK in fourth.

The results were too often frustrating, but I was still really enjoying the IPL experience, which was now starting to feel like a genuine gathering of the global cricketing world. One evening, at a private house party, I was approached by Sir Viv Richards, the legendary West Indies